The Art of the User Interview

Session 04 · Class 3 · Arun Nandewal · 23 Jul 2026

> Your opportunity sits in the user's frustration with the product. They only hand it over when they are relaxed in the conversation. Two dials, run at the same time.

AT A GLANCE

- An interview must produce four things, in order: emotions, touchpoints, generalised pain points, opportunities.
- Ask about journeys, never features. Naming a feature bounds the user's answer to your list.
- Build every question around a **what** and a **how**. Never say **why** out loud.
- A biased question is not repaired. It is deleted and replaced with a behavioural one.
- Six biases: leading, assumptive, confirmation, social desirability, double-barrelled, recency.
- 30–45 minutes, 8–10 questions, 70–80% of the talking done by the user.
- No pattern-hunting before 20–40 interviews. Arun's teams pool 70–80 by splitting the load.

What the interview must produce

Emotions at each step, every touchpoint, those stories generalised into pain points, then converted into opportunities. Features and opinions are not on the list. Arun rejected a student's "the opportunity is the algorithm" mid-demo: the user is an expert on their own experience, an amateur on your architecture.

The emotion–opportunity principle

Growth sits where the user is frustrated. People are at their best when content. So the topic is frustration and the mood is comfort. Open on the person — "Where have you travelled recently?" — push for one concrete memory, then bridge as curiosity: "Maps probably struggles in Kasol. Did you use it?"

Touchpoints: journeys, not features

"Do you use avoid-highways? Petrol pump search?" bounds the answer, makes the user feel tested, and teaches them what you care about. "Walk me through how you go about using it" returns their mental model, in their order, in their words.

MORE CORE CONCEPTS

Journey depth, and the pattern above it

A flat line — "orders grocery in the morning, snacks on weekends" — is not a journey. The good version was time-stamped: bread at 8:15, a protein bar to the office, evening browsing that never converts, cleaning supplies remembered at night. Four use-case types: regular, new, browse-only, scheduled. Read together they gave one finding no single answer held: **Blinkit is a panic button, not a planner.**

When the user gives you nothing

Lower the cost of answering, one rung at a time. Name it without blame — "that's clearly not the most interesting thing you do." Offer a fork: dislike grocery shopping, or is it the app? Then anchor: "In the last two or three orders, where did it annoy you most?"

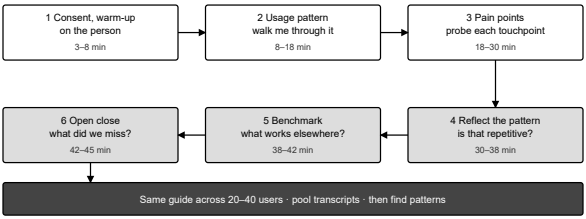
Benchmark, then leave the door open

Users cannot describe an interface that does not exist, but they can point at one that does: "Is there any search anywhere that works well for you?" Close with "what haven't we discussed that I should know?" — that question surfaced recruiters and the Premium paywall, a segment the guide had missed.

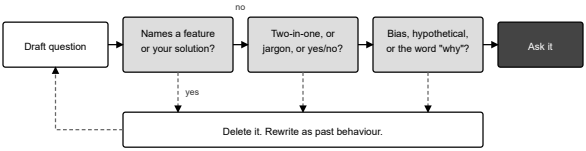
INSTEAD OF THIS, ASK THIS

Instead of	Ask	Fault
"Would you use Maps in an emergency?"	"Walk me through the last time you had to rush somewhere."	Hypothetical, loaded
"What % of rides ended at the right place?"	"Tell me about a time it put you somewhere unexpected."	Data nobody tracks
"Which features do you use — petrol pumps, avoid highways?"	"Walk me through how you use it, from the moment you open it."	Seeds your list
"Would a scheduling notification work on Blinkit?"	"What happens when supplies run out, and how do you restock?"	Solution bias
"Do you always settle debts immediately?"	"Tell me about the last bill you split. How did the money move?"	Social desirability
"Does Zomato have good presence in B2B and B2C?"	"When you want food, which apps do you open, and how?"	Two questions, jargon
"You like LinkedIn search, right?"	"What do you search for most, and how do results turn out?"	Positive leading

THE ARC, AND THE FILTER



The six-stage arc from the live LinkedIn Search interview, with its time boxes. Nothing is analysed until the transcripts are pooled.



Every drafted question runs this gate. A failing question is never repaired in place — it goes back to the top and is rebuilt around something the user has already done.

EXAMPLES FROM CLASS

- **Google Maps ambulance.** A 5-minute hospital run took 30 minutes; the mother was permanently disabled. Nearly every class question was hypothetical, statistical or accusing. It must feel like an interview, not an interrogation.
- **Blinkit.** Four touchpoints in one day, every one reactive. The finding lived in the shape of all four together, not in any single answer.
- **LinkedIn Search.** Exact-name search fails; only location and company carry signal alone. Three follow-ups moved "search is frustrating" into something buildable.
- **Microsoft Excel.** "I don't like the UI" decoded into forgotten VLOOKUP syntax and a two-million-row file hanging for ten minutes. None of it was UI.
- **Apple iPhone.** Apple proves the camera by shooting a whole film on it. What you build and what you sell must be the same story.

TRAPS TO AVOID

Bias	How it shows up
Leading	"Blinkit gives the best discounts — do you agree?"
Assumptive / solution	"Would a front-gate option help at hospitals?"
Confirmation	"What do you love most about UPI apps?"
Social desirability	"Do you always settle debts immediately?"
Double-barrelled	"Good presence in both B2B and B2C?"
Recency / recall	"Everyone's on Meta AI — thoughts?"

WHAT THE INSTRUCTOR STRESSED

- "If the question has a bias, you don't ask that question." No clever rescue.
- Never analyse after one interview. Twenty to forty minimum; teams pool 70–80.
- Everyone asks the same questions. Vary the people, never the ruler.
- Only build on what the user said. A new noun means you've left the Mom Test.

PRACTICE

- ☐ Six questions for the ambulance case: past tense, **what** plus **how**, no feature, no "why".
- ☐ Your own journey for one daily app — five steps, four use-case types, one pattern.
- ☐ Run the research prompt end to end, edit against the pre-flight checklist.
- ☐ Bias teardown: ten questions found in the wild, name and rewrite each.

GLOSSARY

Touchpoint — one point of interaction with the product.

User journey — touchpoints in sequence, with trigger and feeling.

Pain point — a specific point of friction or failure.

Opportunity statement — a pain point rewritten as buildable.

JTBD — the goal the user wants done, independent of product.

Mom Test — their life not your product, past not future.

Discussion guide — the question set, identical across participants.

Reflect-back — replay their words and ask them to confirm.

Benchmarking — asking which other product does this well.

Workaround — what the user invented to route around failure.

VOC — verbatim quotes, in the user's exact words.

5 Whys — a thinking tool for analysis; never spoken aloud.

Task observation — watching them do it instead of asking.

Synthesis — patterns across users, turned into opportunities.